

PARIS — Body Recomposition Plan

Fat loss + muscle gain · "slim muscle" physique

Created: 2026-08-07 · Updated: 2026-08-08 (morning-fasted photo set + carb protocol) Profile: Female, 28 y/o, 154 cm, 46.7 kg, moderately-high body fat % Goal: Lose body fat, gain muscle — the slim, defined look, not a heavily-built physique Equipment: Dumbbells, yoga mat, home space Current training: Pilates 2×/week (Mon = abs, Sat = back/arms)

General fitness and nutrition information, not medical advice. See §10 Health Flags — there is one item worth discussing with a doctor.

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1. Diagnosis — why you look soft at a low weight

BMI = $46.7 \div 1.54^2 = 19.7$ — a normal, even lowish weight. At 44 kg you were BMI 18.6, which is underweight, and you still looked soft. That is the whole answer:

The problem is not too much weight. It is not enough muscle.

What the old protocol did:

What you did	What it actually caused
Fasted HIIT 3–5×/week, 30 min	High cortisol / high fatigue, low muscle-building stimulus
Carbs under 50 g/day	Depleted glycogen (looks "flat", not firm), poor training output
No progressive resistance training	Nothing signalling the body to keep or build muscle
Aggressive deficit sustained long-term	Weight loss came heavily from lean mass + water, not only fat

When muscle is lost at roughly the same rate as fat, body fat percentage barely moves. You get smaller with identical softness — arms, stomach, thighs, back. Exactly the outcome you described.

So the lever going forward is build muscle, not lose more weight. Expect the scale to go up toward 48–50 kg over 6–12 months while looking visibly leaner. That is success.

You cannot spot-reduce. No amount of ab work removes stomach fat. Firmness comes from muscle underneath plus a modest overall fat reduction.

2. Baseline photo assessment

Two sets read: Set 1 — evening, post-meal, warm overhead lighting. Set 2 — morning, fasted, after the bathroom, before water, natural daylight. Directional, not measurement.

The single most useful finding: Set 1 vs Set 2

Same body, days apart — no meaningful composition change is possible in that window. Yet the lower belly, the primary concern, is substantially reduced in the morning set. The abdomen in the fasted side profile is close to flat.

That difference is not fat. It is the four non-fat contributors listed below: post-meal distension, a high-fibre veggie load, digestive volume, and cycle timing. This is now personally documented rather than theoretical.

Implication beyond tracking: assessing yourself in the evening, in a mirror, under overhead light means forming your body image from the worst-case view of yourself. A real and common distortion — and your own photos disprove it.

Headline

Not fat — slim with low muscle mass. Limbs are slim, waist is narrow, collarbones visible, frame is small. What reads as "fat" is mostly absence of muscle underneath, plus a posture issue exaggerating one area.

Visual body fat estimate: low-to-mid 20s%, $\pm 4\%$ — revised down from mid-to-high 20s after Set 2. In natural light while fasted there is visible abdominal structure, a clear waist taper, and scapular definition.

Region by region

Region	Observation	Priority
Shoulders	Narrow, sloping, almost no lateral deltoid cap. Biggest single opportunity — deltoid width creates waist contrast. Unchanged across both sets.	★★★
Upper back	Limited lat / mid-trap development → little taper from shoulder to waist. Some scapular definition visible fasted.	★★★
Glutes	Revised up after Set 2. Real shape and a visible glute–hamstring tie-in — Set 1's downward lighting and stance made them look flatter than they are. Still the main lower-body opportunity, but not flat.	★★
Lower abdomen	Real softness in the evening; close to flat fasted. Mostly timing, not fat. See breakdown below.	★★
Arms / baseline	Revised up after Set 2. Visible ab outline while fasted and defined shoulder blades mean more muscle underneath than Set 1 suggested. Untrained, not depleted.	★★
Legs	Slim. Some softness front/inner thigh, no excess size. Do not train legs to make them smaller — there is nothing to remove.	—

The finding that matters most: posture — CONFIRMED

Both sets show the same pattern, and Set 2's natural light makes it unambiguous:

Forward head — chin sits well ahead of the shoulder line; more visible fasted

Rounded upper back — thoracic flexion, shoulders drifting forward

Anterior pelvic tilt — pronounced lumbar curve. The residual lower-belly protrusion in the fasted side profile comes from pelvic position, not fat

This is a large part of why the stomach looks the way it does. Anterior tilt physically protrudes the lower belly; rounded shoulders compress the torso visually. Correcting posture alone typically produces a visible side-profile change in 4–8 weeks — faster than any safe rate of fat loss.

Lower belly — five contributors, only one is fat

1. Anterior pelvic tilt (postural — fixable in weeks)
2. Subcutaneous fat (real, but the last site to respond in women — be patient)
3. Bloating / distension (evening, post-meal, high veggie intake — normal, can be several cm)
4. Weak deep core / transverse abdominis
5. Cycle phase

More crunches address none of the top four.

What this changed in the plan

Three training adjustments, all folded into §4 below:

1. Added a 5-minute posture block, 4x/week — highest-return item in the plan, and the one thing here that changes fast
2. Promoted the hip thrust to first exercise on Tuesday, 4 sets
3. Flagged lateral raises + reverse flies as non-skippable

And one strategic change from Set 2:

4. The case for ever cutting got weaker. At low-to-mid 20s% and 46.7 kg there is maybe 1–1.5 kg of fat worth losing — down from the 1.5–2.5 kg estimated off Set 1. That is almost nothing. Stripping it would cost muscle you don't have to spare and lead straight back to the 44 kg loop. See §9 — Option B is now actively discouraged.

Nothing in either set suggests eating less.

Honest caveat on morning-fasted photos

Morning-fasted is the flattering end of your daily range, exactly as evening-post-meal is the unflattering end. Real appearance sits between them. Use morning-fasted for tracking because it is the most reproducible condition — not because it looks best. The point is comparing like to like over months.

3. Nutrition

Calorie targets

Mifflin-St Jeor BMR = $(10 \times 46.7) + (6.25 \times 154) - (5 \times 28) - 161 = \approx 1,130$ kcal With 2 Pilates + 3 lifting sessions + daily walking (activity factor ≈ 1.4 – 1.5):

Maintenance $\approx 1,600$ – $1,700$ kcal/day

Phase	Duration	Intake	Purpose
Phase 1 — Recover & build	Months 1–4	1,650–1,700 kcal (maintenance)	Rebuild muscle, restore metabolism after long restriction

Phase	Duration	Intake	Purpose
Phase 2 — Optional mild cut	Months 5–7, rarely needed	1,450–1,500 kcal	Small deficit while keeping the new muscle. Discouraged after the Set 2 photos — see §9.
Back to maintenance	after any cut	1,650–1,750	Never diet continuously

Do not go below ~1,400 kcal. You have already spent a long stretch under-eating; going lower again repeats the exact result you're unhappy with.

Starting at maintenance rather than a deficit is deliberate — recomposition works best for someone (a) new to resistance training and (b) coming off under-eating. Both true.

Macros at 1,650 kcal

Macro	Target	Calories	Why
Protein	100–105 g (~2.1 g/kg)	400–420	The single biggest lever. Non-negotiable.
Fat	50–60 g	450–540	Hormones, cycle health, satiety. Never below ~40 g.
Carbs	170–190 g	680–760	Training fuel, muscle fullness, thyroid/cycle support
Fiber	25–30 g	—	Veggie intake likely covers this already

Carbs go from under 50 g back up to ~180 g. Intentional. Carbs are what let you push hard in a lifting session, and glycogen is what makes muscle look full rather than flat. Some early scale increase will be glycogen and water. That is not fat.

Carbohydrate protocol — daily and per meal

Target ~180 g/day, varied by training load. The weekly average is what matters, not any single day.

Day	Sessions	Carbs
Tue / Thu / Sun	Dumbbell lifting	190–200 g
Mon / Sat	Pilates	175–185 g
Wed / Fri	Rest / walking	150–160 g

This also auto-manages calories — more food on hard days, less on easy ones, with no extra tracking.

The mental model: 6 carb units

Stop counting grams. One unit $\approx$ 30 g carbs:

Food	One unit
自製無糖饅頭	1 medium (~60 g)
米飯 (cooked)	100 g — a small rice bowl
酸種法棍	55 g — about two finger-widths
純燕麥 (dry)	45 g
Kodiak 鬆餅	1 serving
Banana	1 medium
Apple	1 large

Lifting days = 6 units. Pilates days = 6. Rest days = 5. That is the whole system.

Per-meal breakdown

Lifting day (~195 g):

Meal	Carbs	What that looks like
Breakfast	45 g	1 饅頭 (70 g) + veggies + a little milk
Pre-workout (60–90 min before)	30 g	1 Kodiak 鬆餅 or 40 g 純燕麥
Lunch	50 g	150 g 米飯 + big veggie plate
Snack	20 g	Greek yogurt + 100 g fruit
Dinner	45 g	65 g 酸種法棍 + veggies

Rest day (~155 g): drop the pre-workout serving. Everything else identical.

Per-meal ceiling ~60 g. Not for fat-loss reasons — larger single loads are simply where bloating and energy dips come from.

Ramp up — do not jump straight to 180 g

Coming from under 50 g, an overnight jump causes real GI discomfort and 1–2 kg of water gain in a week, which reads as failure and ends the plan. Phase it:

Week	Carbs	Units
1	~100 g	3–4
2	~140 g	4–5
3	~170 g	5–6
4 onward	~180 g	6

Protein stays at 100 g throughout — it does not ramp. Calories rise as carbs rise. That is intended, not a mistake.

Five rules

1. Anchor the biggest servings around training. The pre-workout unit is the highest-value carb of the day — it is what lets you add weight to the dumbbells.
2. Never train fasted, and never let breakfast be zero-carb if lifting later.
3. Vegetables are effectively free. A large plate is 5–10 g. Not part of the 6 units.
4. Fruit counts and is fine. 1–2 servings/day. No reason to avoid it.
5. Expect 1–2 kg on the scale in the first fortnight. Each gram of glycogen holds ~3 g of water. That is the "full" look you have been missing, not fat returning.

The number will feel enormous compared to the old intake. It is normal for an active woman of this size — the previous protocol ran at roughly a quarter of it.

Protein distribution

Spread across 3–4 meals of 25–35 g each, not one large protein dinner.

Food	Serving	Protein
雞胸 (chicken breast)	130 g raw	~31 g
三文魚 (salmon)	100 g raw	~20 g

Food	Serving	Protein
蒸魚 (steamed fish)	150 g	~28 g
水煮蝦 (boiled shrimp)	120 g	~23 g
吊龍 (beef)	100 g	~20 g (high fat — count it)
Whole egg	1	~6 g
Egg white	1	~3.5 g
Kodiak 鬆餅	1 serving w/ milk	~14 g
純燕麥 (oats)	40 g dry	~5 g
自製無糖饅頭	1 (~70 g)	~5 g
酸種法棍	60 g	~5 g
米飯	150 g cooked	~4 g

Gaps in the current diet

Good quality overall, but carb-heavy relative to protein, and missing:

1. Dairy / soy / legumes — Greek yogurt (0–2%), cottage cheese, 豆腐, 毛豆, unsweetened 豆漿, lentils.
Cheapest way to close a protein gap.
2. A protein powder — whey or plant. Not magic, just the easiest way to hit 100 g on a busy day. One scoop $\approx$ 24 g protein / 120 kcal.
3. Calcium + vitamin D — important for a small-framed woman lifting, often low without dairy.
4. Iron — menstruating female with a restriction history. Check ferritin if persistently tired.

吊龍: fine iron/creatine source but a fatty cut. Keep to ~100 g and count it against the fat budget, or it quietly eats the carb budget.

Sample day (~1,650 kcal, ~105 g protein)

Breakfast — ~440 kcal, 29 g P

2 whole eggs + 3 egg whites (210 kcal, 24 g P)

1 自製無糖饅頭, ~70 g (170 kcal, 5 g P)

炒青菜 with 1 tsp oil (60 kcal)

Lunch — ~460 kcal, 35 g P

130 g raw 雞胸 (165 kcal, 31 g P)

150 g cooked 米飯 (195 kcal, 4 g P)

Large plate of veggies + 1 tsp oil (100 kcal)

Snack — ~200 kcal, 20 g P

150 g Greek yogurt 0–2% (100 kcal, 15 g P) or 1 scoop whey (120 kcal, 24 g P)

100 g fruit (55 kcal)

Dinner — ~480 kcal, 26 g P

100 g raw 三文魚 (205 kcal, 20 g P) — or 150 g 蒸魚 / 120 g 水煮蝦

60 g 酸種法棍 (160 kcal, 5 g P)

Veggies + 1 tsp oil (110 kcal)

Lifting days add: 1 serving Kodiak 鬆餅 (~190 kcal, 14 g P) or 40 g 純燕麥 with milk, pre- or post-workout → ~1,800 kcal. Correct on hard days.

(Estimates. Weigh food for 2–3 weeks to calibrate your eyes, then stop.)

Meal timing

Stop training fasted. Eat 60–90 min before lifting: ~30 g carbs + ~20 g protein (饅頭 + eggs, or a Kodiak pancake). Fasted training was working against you.

Protein-containing meal within ~2 hours after training. The window is overrated; the daily total is what matters.

Meal frequency otherwise doesn't matter. Eat on a schedule you can sustain.

Supplements

Supplement	Dose	Verdict
Creatine monohydrate	3–5 g/day, any time	Best-supported supplement for muscle/strength. Works in women. Does not cause bulk. Adds ~0.5–1 kg intramuscular water — that's the point.
Vitamin D3	1,000–2,000 IU	If limited sun exposure
Whey / plant protein	as needed	Convenience only
Fat burners / detox / 減肥茶	—	Skip. All of them.

4. Training

Core principle

Pilates is excellent for control, posture and core, but provides no progressive load — it won't build noticeable muscle alone. Keep both classes, add 3 short dumbbell sessions.

HIIT: drop from 3–5×/week to 0–1×/week, max 10–15 min, never fasted, never as the main strategy. Replace with walking (7,000–9,000 steps/day) — nearly the same weekly burn, almost no recovery cost, doesn't compete with lifting.

Weekly schedule

Day	Session	Time
Mon	Pilates (abs) + 20 min walk	60 min
Tue	Day A — Lower body	35–40 min
Wed	Walk / mobility / rest	20–30 min
Thu	Day B — Upper body	35–40 min
Fri	Walk / rest	20–30 min
Sat	Pilates (back + arms)	60 min
Sun	Day C — Full body + glutes	35 min

5 sessions, 3 with progressive load. Don't add a 4th lifting day — add load, not days.

Day A — Lower body (Tuesday)

Hip thrust promoted to first per photo assessment — trained fresh, extra set.

#	Exercise	Sets × Reps	Notes
1	DB floor hip thrust / glute bridge ★	4 × 12–15	DB across hips, 2-sec squeeze at top. Do this fresh.
2	Goblet squat	3 × 8–12	One DB at chest. Depth over weight.
3	DB Romanian deadlift	3 × 8–12	Hinge at hips, soft knees, feel hamstrings
4	DB reverse lunge	3 × 8–10 per leg	Step backward — easier on knees
5	Standing calf raise	2 × 15–20	
6	Side-lying hip abduction	2 × 15 per side	On the mat

Day B — Upper body (Thursday)

#	Exercise	Sets × Reps	Notes
1	DB floor press	3 × 8–12	Lying on mat — safe without a bench
2	One-arm DB row	3 × 8–12 per side	Brace on chair/sofa. Best back exercise.
3	DB shoulder press	3 × 8–12	Seated or standing
4	Bent-over reverse fly ★	3 × 12–15	Light weight. Posture + upper-back definition. Never skip.
5	DB lateral raise ★	2 × 12–15	Shoulder width is what makes a waist look small. Never skip.
6	DB biceps curl	2 × 10–12	
7	Overhead triceps extension	2 × 10–12	The back-of-arm area
8	Push-ups (incline or knee)	2 × AMRAP	Finisher

★ #4 and #5 are last, feel unimportant, and do more for the silhouette than anything else in the program. The photos make this specific: narrow sloping shoulders and a flat upper back are the two things most responsible for the look you want to change.

Day C — Full body + glutes (Sunday)

#	Exercise	Sets × Reps	Notes
1	DB deadlift from floor	3 × 8–10	Both DBs, flat back
2	Bulgarian split squat	3 × 8–10 per leg	Rear foot on chair/sofa. Brutal, very effective.
3	DB floor press or push-up	3 × 10	
4	One-arm row or renegade row	3 × 8–10 per side	
5	DB step-up	2 × 10 per leg	Stairs or sturdy chair
6	Suitcase carry	3 × 30–40 sec	One DB, walk. Best real core exercise.

Rest between sets: 60–90 sec. Warm up 5 min (leg swings, arm circles, bodyweight squats, cat-cow) before every session.

Posture block — 5 min, 4×/week ★ NEW

Added from the photo assessment. Fastest visible win in the whole plan. Do it after lifting or before bed.

Exercise	Dose	Targets
Wall angels	2 × 10 slow	Thoracic extension, shoulder position
Doorway pec stretch	2 × 30 sec	Tight chest from rounding
Thoracic extension over rolled towel (across mid-back)	2 min	Rounded upper back
Half-kneeling hip flexor stretch	30 sec/side	Anterior pelvic tilt → lower belly

Core work

Two Pilates classes already cover abs well. Optional extra 2×/week after lifting: dead bug 3 × 10/side, side plank 3 × 20–30 sec/side, hollow hold 3 × 20 sec.

This does not burn stomach fat. It builds the muscle underneath and supports the deep core that the posture block addresses.

Progressive overload — the part that actually matters

This is what the old routine was missing entirely. Same workout at the same difficulty forever produces no change.

The rule: the last 2 reps of every working set should be genuinely hard (1–2 reps in reserve). Complete the top of the rep range on all sets for 2 sessions running → increase the weight.

If dumbbells are too light to increase, make each rep harder instead, in this order:

1. Slow the lowering phase to 3–4 seconds
2. Add a 1–2 second pause at the hardest point
3. Go unilateral — one leg / one arm
4. Increase reps to 15–20 and add a 4th set
5. Shorten rest to 45 sec
6. Then: buy heavier dumbbells

Log every session. Exercise, weight, sets, reps. A phone note is fine. The training log is the primary evidence this is working — long before the mirror shows it.

Equipment — the real constraint

This stops most people at home, and it will hit around week 8–14.

Within 6 months you should be goblet squatting 16–20 kg and RDL-ing 2×12–15 kg. If your dumbbells top out at 5 kg you will stall hard, and tempo tricks won't fully compensate.

Buy adjustable dumbbells reaching at least 20 kg each — the single highest-return purchase for this plan. Cheaper alternative: pairs at 5 / 8 / 10 / 12.5 kg plus resistance bands.

5. Why this works — the mechanism

"How can eating more not gain fat, but lose fat and gain muscle?"

a. "Eating more" is relative to your maintenance

1,650 kcal is roughly what your body burns in a day. It only feels like a lot compared to your old restricted intake (~1,100–1,300). Fat gain requires eating above maintenance. Eating at maintenance doesn't add fat — it just stops the deficit. You're not adding energy, you're redirecting it.

b. The arithmetic — the amounts involved are tiny

1 kg of muscle costs ~5,000–6,000 kcal to build (muscle is ~75% water — energetically cheap)

1 kg of body fat stores ~7,700 kcal

A realistic rate is ~0.3 kg muscle/month = ~1,700 kcal over a month = ~57 kcal/day. The body pulls that from fat stores, and 1,700 kcal of fat = 0.22 kg.

One month at exact maintenance:

	Change
Muscle	+0.3 kg
Fat	0.22 kg
Scale	+0.08 kg (nothing)
Waist	down

The two flows are small enough to cancel on the scale. Over 6 months: +1.8 kg muscle, 1.3 kg fat. On a 46.7 kg frame that's a large visual change — muscle occupies ~18% less volume per kg than fat, so you get visibly smaller at the same weight.

c. Calories decide how much you weigh; protein and lifting decide what it's made of

Same 1,650 kcal, two outcomes:

Low protein, no resistance training → nothing signals the body to build or keep muscle; spare energy defaults to fat.

100 g protein + progressive overload → training creates the demand, protein supplies the material, the body preferentially routes energy into muscle repair and growth.

This is nutrient partitioning — the actual mechanism, and why "just eat less" produced the result you didn't want.

d. Why it works for you specifically

Recomposition isn't universal. It works best when these are true — all four are:

1. Untrained — never done progressive resistance training. Novices gain fastest.
2. Coming off a long deficit — regaining lost muscle is far faster than building new (muscle cells retain their nuclei).
3. Higher fat relative to lean mass — plenty of stored fuel to power the building.
4. Protein was too low — easiest variable to fix, biggest effect.

An experienced lifter at 15% body fat eating enough protein cannot do this. You can.

e. Honest caveats

The scale rises in weeks 1–4 and not all of it is nothing. 50 g → 180 g carbs adds ~300–500 g glycogen, each gram holding ~3 g water → 1–2 kg water weight. Creatine adds another 0.5–1 kg. That's most of it. But if your metabolism is currently suppressed from long restriction, real maintenance may sit below 1,650 for a few weeks, so a small amount of genuine fat gain is possible early. Worth it to restore metabolic rate.

1,650 is a formula estimate, ±10–15%. Real maintenance is what the tape says after four weeks.

This is slow. ~0.3 kg muscle and ~0.2 kg fat per month. It will not look dramatic at week 6.

It expires. After 6–12 months you're no longer a novice and must pick a direction.

6. "Will this make me bulky?"

Goal is the slim, defined figure — not a heavily-built influencer physique. This plan produces the former and cannot accidentally produce the latter.

You cannot accidentally get there

Period	Natural muscle gained (female)
Year 1 (best year you'll ever have)	~2.5–3 kg
Year 2	~1–1.5 kg
Year 3	~0.5–0.7 kg
Year 4+	~0.3 kg/year

Lifetime natural ceiling at 154 cm is maybe 5–7 kg of muscle across an entire body, over a decade.

The physiques in question come from 5–6 training days/week, 20+ hard sets per muscle group, deliberate surpluses of 300–500 kcal held for years, heavy barbell work — and in a meaningful share of that content, undisclosed performance-enhancing drugs.

You're doing three 35-minute dumbbell sessions at maintenance. Not the same activity.

The reframe

"Slim and toned" and "muscular" are the same road — different distances, not different directions. You're at kilometre zero. The look you want is at kilometre 3. The look you fear is at kilometre 40, uphill, requiring years of deliberate surplus.

You will not blow past your exit without noticing. You'd have years of monthly progress photos showing you approaching it, and stopping is as simple as no longer adding weight. Nothing here is fast, and nothing here is irreversible.

The uncomfortable part

The slim figure you want is literally made of muscle. Firm arms = deltoid and triceps under low body fat. A flat defined stomach = abs that exist. The "lifted" look = glutes. The line down the back = lats and rear delts.

The alternative — losing weight without building muscle — produces skinny and soft. You already ran that experiment at 44 kg.

The "toning" myth

High reps don't "tone", low reps don't "bulk". Muscle grows across essentially every rep range when sets are taken near failure. "Toned" just means muscle plus low body fat. You cannot change a muscle's shape — only its size and the fat covering it.

What actually makes people look thick

Two things, neither in this plan:

1. Caloric surplus — muscle plus a fat layer reads as thick. Physique athletes look big in the off-season and defined when they cut: same muscle, different fat. You're at maintenance — definition without the layer.

2. Deliberate specialization — heavy shrugs (thick neck), very high-volume quad work (thick legs), 20+ glute sets/week. This plan has six glute-focused sets a week and no shrugs at all.

The muscles that make you look smaller

Muscle	Effect
Lateral delts ★	Widens shoulders slightly → waist looks smaller by contrast. The most "slimming" muscle on the body.
Upper back / rear delts ★	V-taper, plus posture — standing tall alone takes visual centimetres off a stomach
Glutes + hamstrings	Shape and leg line without adding thigh circumference the way quad specialization does
Triceps	The back-of-arm softness

Day B's last exercises are lateral raises and reverse flies. The program was written for the slim look from the start.

Two optional tweaks to lean further in

Keep quad volume where it is — don't add squat/lunge work beyond what's written.

Never skip lateral raises and reverse flies.

If anything ever looks bigger than you want, drop that exercise and it reverses in weeks. At 0.3 kg of muscle per month across the whole body, that decision is years away — and you'll have the photos to see it coming.

7. Tracking progress

The scale is the worst possible metric here, because muscle gain and fat loss cancel on it.

Metric	Frequency	How
Tape measurements ★	Every 2 weeks	Morning, fasted, before drinking. Waist at navel, hips at widest, mid-thigh, upper arm relaxed.
Photos ★	Monthly	Protocol below
Strength log ★	Every session	Weight × reps rising = muscle being built
Body weight	Weekly average only	Never judge a single day. Expect it to drift up.
How clothes fit	Ongoing	Underrated and honest

Success looks like: waist down 2–4 cm, arms and thighs the same or slightly larger, scale up 1–2 kg, strength up substantially.

Photo protocol ★ NEW

The 2026-08-08 baseline set works, but standardize from here so comparisons are honest:

Morning, fasted, after the bathroom, before drinking — evening abdominal distension is real and will make you think you regressed

Natural light from the front, not overhead warm lighting — an overhead pendant casts downward shadows that exaggerate everything

Same spot, same clothes, same distance, feet marked on the floor

Relaxed and neutral — don't suck in, don't pose. Then take one flexed shot, it's genuinely informative

Same week of your cycle each month

Keep the flexed back shot. In six months it will be the most satisfying comparison you have.

Realistic timeline

Period	What to expect
Weeks 1–4	Strength jumps quickly (mostly neural). Scale up 0.5–1 kg from restored glycogen and water — not fat. Possible mild bloating as carbs return.
Months 2–3	Measurements move. Posture change becomes visible in the side profile. Upper back and arms feel firmer. Energy and sleep better than on the old protocol.
Months 4–6	Visible recomposition. Photos start showing it clearly.
Months 6–12	Meaningful change to the soft look. ~0.2–0.5 kg muscle/month at best — slow is normal, and permanent in a way crash dieting never is.

The last approach produced a fast scale result and no composition change. This one produces a slow scale result and a real composition change.

8. The week-8 checkpoint

Check tape measurements against the training log. One adjustment maximum, then keep going.

Result	Meaning	Action
Waist flat or down + strength clearly up	Working	Change nothing
Waist up 2+ cm + strength up	Real surplus	Drop 150 kcal (carbs), re-check in 4 weeks
Waist up + strength flat	Overeating and under-training	Fix the training log first, not the food
Waist down + strength flat/dropping	Under-eating	Add 150 kcal

Week 8 is a checkpoint, not a phase end. The plan continues either way.

9. Roadmap beyond week 8

The program doesn't expire — progress does. Keep the same plan as long as the weights in your log are climbing. Change it when they stop, not on a calendar date.

Weeks 9–12 — same plan, heavier

Nothing changes but the numbers. Realistic by now: goblet squat ~6 kg → ~10–12 kg, RDL 2×5 kg → 2×9–10 kg. If those haven't moved, that's the problem — not exercise selection.

Week 12: deload week. Same exercises, same weights, half the sets. One week. Skip it and you'll stall around week 14 wondering why.

Weeks 13–24 — same structure, refreshed exercises

Swap movements but keep the pattern identical (a squat stays a squat, a hinge stays a hinge):

Old	New
Goblet squat	DB front squat (both DBs at shoulders)

Old	New
DB reverse lunge	Walking lunge or lateral lunge
DB floor press	Push-up variations / single-arm floor press
One-arm row	Chest-supported row or wide-grip row
Shoulder press	Arnold press or Z-press

Also increase from 3 → 4 sets on the first two exercises of each day. Volume is the main progression lever once weight increases slow.

Nutrition: unchanged at 1,650, or nudge to 1,700–1,750 if strength is consistently rising and the tape is stable. More muscle = higher maintenance. Intake should slowly rise over time, not fall.

Week 24: deload again.

Month 6 — the fork

Option	When	Protocol
A. Keep recomping ★ most likely correct	Waist down, strength up, looking better	Change nothing. Novice recomposition often runs a full year.
C. Small surplus ★ now the strong second choice	Frustrated by slow muscle gain	1,800–1,850 kcal for 12–16 weeks. Builds muscle fastest; the most honest answer to "I look soft" — but the scale climbs and most people can't tolerate it psychologically.
B. Short cut ▲ actively discouraged	—	1,450–1,500 kcal for 8–12 weeks max, protein at 100 g, lifting identical. Only if a great deal changes. At low-to-mid 20s% body fat there is ~1–1.5 kg of fat worth losing; a cut would cost muscle you cannot spare and lead back to the 44 kg loop.

The rule that matters most: don't cut until you have something worth revealing. A cut reveals muscle, it doesn't create it. Cutting at month 3 puts you back at 44 kg and soft — the exact loop already run.

When to actually change the program

When any one of these is true — not on a schedule:

Same weight × same reps for 3 consecutive sessions on a lift, with decent sleep and food

Dumbbells maxed out on the main lifts

Bored enough to be skipping sessions (adherence beats optimization)

Otherwise: same plan, heavier weights, indefinitely. Boring consistency is the whole method.

Measure every 2 weeks, change something every 4 weeks minimum. Two-week data is mostly noise — water, cycle phase, sodium, digestion.

10. Health flags — please read

The previous protocol — under 50 g carbs, fasted HIIT 3–5×/week, BMI 18.6 at 44 kg — is a recognised risk profile for RED-S (Relative Energy Deficiency in Sport) / low energy availability. Worth taking seriously rather than dismissing.

See a doctor if any of these apply, currently or from that period:

Irregular, very light, or absent menstrual cycles

Persistently cold hands and feet

Poor sleep, hair shedding, brittle nails

Frequent illness, low mood, or unusual fatigue

Any history of disordered eating patterns

Ask for bloodwork including ferritin, vitamin D, thyroid (TSH/T3/T4), and a full blood count. Cheap standard tests that would show whether anything needs correcting before training hard.

Nothing in this plan requires going below ~1,400 kcal. Wanting to is the signal to talk to a professional rather than cut further.

11. Quick summary

1. Eat more, not less — 1,650–1,700 kcal at maintenance for at least 4 months.
2. 100 g protein daily, spread over 3–4 meals. Biggest single lever.
3. Carbs back to ~180 g = 6 units/day, ramped over 4 weeks. Existing carb sources are good.
4. 3 dumbbell sessions/week with progressive overload. Keep both Pilates classes.
5. HIIT down to 0–1×/week, never fasted. Walk 7–9k steps instead.
6. 5-minute posture block 4×/week — fastest visible win, addresses the lower belly.
7. Hip thrusts first on Tuesday. Never skip lateral raises or reverse flies.
8. Track tape, photos, and strength — not the scale. Expect the scale to rise.
9. Photograph morning-fasted only. Evening distension is most of what looked like belly fat.
10. You will not get bulky. Physically cannot happen at this rate, at maintenance.
11. Do not cut. There is ~1–1.5 kg of fat worth losing. Build instead.
12. Give it 6 months. Consider creatine. Get bloodwork if any health flags apply.